

How to Open Linguistic Doors:
A Sociological Analysis of *Chants of Sennaar*

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Communication, while something many take for granted, is one of the foundational elements on which societies are built. One's communication, or more specifically, one's knowledge of a society's languages, directly determines their access to resources, including work, education, and many other services and social networks that are vital for an individual to thrive in their society. Without this knowledge, one becomes an outsider, much like how *Chants of Sennaar* begins. The protagonist awakes at the base of a tower of divided peoples with nothing besides a journal and pen. To progress, the player must guide the protagonist to the top of the tower, deciphering each language as they climb. Through *Chants of Sennaar's* puzzle-solving mechanics, the player is encouraged to immerse themselves within each fictional language, gaining linguistic capital for each society, only to ultimately use this capital to deconstruct the very social stratification that makes each language so valuable within their societies.

To ascend the tower and decipher these languages, the player must engage with the core gameplay loop of *Chants of Sennaar*—the player discovers new symbols within context of the environment or within context of other symbols. The player uses this context to extrapolate meaning and record their guesses within their journal. After completing puzzles and challenges using these guesses, the protagonist gives the player the opportunity to match the symbols to images, which if matched successfully, reveal the true meaning of the symbols within their language (Rundisc, 2023).

Since *Chants of Sennaar* is a singleplayer game that focuses on the communities and cultures within the game, players most likely to engage with this loop are those interested in interacting specifically with the game's world, mapping them directly onto

the achiever and explorer player types from Bartle's taxonomy (Floyd, 2015). These players are motivated to act on and interact with the game world, which manifests during gameplay as overcoming puzzles, discovering new information, and ultimately—if the player seeks the game's true ending—using their exploration to achieve full translations of every language (Rundisc, 2023). *Chants of Sennaar* caters directly to these player types by gating achievement behind exploration and gating further exploration behind achievement, guiding players into a cycle of seeking new clues, using these clues to progress, and using that progression to seek new clues.

As the player engages with this gameplay loop, they are unwittingly increasing their linguistic capital, a theory posited by Pierre Bourdieu, defined as the language skills and styles that a society values in an individual (1991, p. 18). As the player betters their communication with the different peoples, their value within each society increases, and they gain greater access to that society's resources. This manifests in game through access to new areas, new items, and new dialogue that help the player continue to progress forward (Rundisc, 2023).

Still, the player gaining linguistic capital does not immediately aid the tower's residents. Social stratification, defined as the organization of people into hierarchies due to power structures, manifests both figuratively and literally in *Chants of Sennaar*—each cultural group separated into horizontal layers that stack to make the tower's hierarchy ("Major Theoretical Perspectives on Social Stratification," 2023; Rundisc, 2023). However, unlike real-world accounts of social stratification, where popular theories posit that divides occur primarily due to merit, economic imbalance, or differing social and political influence, the divides within *Chants of Sennaar* exist primarily due to language

barriers between the game's five cultural groups—Devotee, Warrior, Bard, Alchemist, and Anchorite (“Major Theoretical Perspectives on Social Stratification,” 2023; Rundisc, 2023).

This stratification began when the different cultures started to fear one another, leading to social othering—the construction of in-groups and out-groups within each society to alienate the out-groups (Brons, 2015; Rundisc, 2023). This can be seen as the word for “Devotee” in the Warrior’s language is “impure” and the word for “slave” in the Bard’s language is “idiot” (Rundisc, 2023). It is also apparent that, through these demeaning names, social othering and alienation have been reinforced by linguistic relativity—the theory that one’s language influences how one thinks (Casasanto, 2016; Rundisc, 2023). Linguistic relativity can even lead groups to contribute to their own oppression, seen through the Devotees’ card game considering the “Warrior” card more powerful than the “Devotee” card (Rundisc, 2023). Furthermore, the Warrior’s word for “Bard,” is “the chosen,” which, combined with the warrior’s idolization of music, suggests that the Warriors think the Bards have greater value or importance (Rundisc, 2023). The words one group attributes to other groups describe how they feel about those groups and about themselves, both in connotation and denotation, shaping how they perceive the world they live in.

With the groups separated physically, culturally, socially, and linguistically, it is the duty of the player to use contact theory to bring them all together. Contact theory states that prejudice can be reduced through “personal and positive contact between groups” (Lytle, 2018, p. 418). According to Lytle, Gordon W. Allport—the original proponent of contact theory—proposed four optimal conditions for prejudice reduction, but modern

studies have shown that, even without these conditions, intergroup contact leads to reduction in prejudice (2018, pp. 418-419).

As the player gains linguistic capital in each society, their value in those societies increases until they have reached higher in the tower than any person before them, aiding in their credibility. With high linguistic capital from all five societies, the player has the ability to facilitate communication between groups of the tower, eventually showing them that they have common goals. For instance, the plants in the Devotees' garden are dying; the player translates this to an Alchemist, and the Alchemist decides to create a "formula" that will aid the plant's growth (Rundisc, 2023). Then, when the player returns to the garden, the plants are no longer wilted, and the greenhouse keeper and Alchemist examine the plants together, visibly happy (Rundisc, 2023).

If the player facilitates communication between every different group of the tower, they achieve the true ending where all groups work together in harmony, learning that the symbols for what each culture values most—God, Duty, Beauty, Transformation, and Exile—are truly made out of the same three-dimensional shape, rotated and viewed from different angles (Rundisc, 2023). At the top of the tower, the five cultures finally come an understanding, officially ending the divide between these disparate, but ultimately similar groups.

Even unbeknownst to most players, *Chants of Sennaar* encourages those who play it to aid in the communication necessary to deconstruct the social stratification of a divided tower, allowing for the creation of a brighter future. To do this, *Chants of Sennaar* facilitates a gameplay loop designed to entice achievers and explorers to continuously gain linguistic capital and use that capital to make a difference. During this,

players overcome obstacles such as social othering and consider cultural differences through linguistic relativity. By the end, players are left with a fascinating examination of their own cultural divides through the lens of a stratified tower, finally healed through contact and communication.

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